



START IT

RIGHT NOW. NOT MONDAY.

OR



STALL IT

YOUR FREE NINE-DAY GUIDE TO GET STARTED.

Nine days. Two tracks. No excuses left to make.

[START HERE](#)

INTRODUCTION

Before anything else — this guide is a starting point, not a program built for you. It doesn't know if your left knee clicks on the way down, whether you're coeliac, training around a shoulder reconstruction, or trying to eat around shift work. It can't. It's general. If any of that sounds like you, get proper eyes on it before you push hard — a GP, a physio, or a coach who can actually see you move and eat.

What this guide can do is give you the same starting sequence I give anyone walking in the door with no plan. Nine days, two tracks running side by side — training and nutrition — each stepping up through four levels. Level 1 is the floor: the stuff that has to be non-negotiable before anything else matters. Level 4 is still a beginner's ceiling, not an advanced program — this guide stops there on purpose.

You'll notice the levels get more specific as they go. That's deliberate. Level 1 is "show up and do this." By Level 4 we're talking tempo, volume, and things like progressive overload and rate of perceived exertion — terms I've deliberately left in, because you'll hit them the moment you look past the basics, and it's better you meet them here first. Everything past what fits in nine days — the actual programming, the calorie and macro targets built around your body, the adjustments week to week — is what's in the full Fuel It or Fail It and Lift It or Lose It guides, or what I do one-on-one in coaching.

Nine days. Two tracks. Read each day, do it, move to the next.

— **Hayden**

DAY 01 • TRAINING LEVEL 01

SHOW UP, DON'T THINK

Level 1 has nothing to do with exercise selection. It's about proving to yourself that you'll actually turn up.

THE ONLY GOAL TODAY

Pick three days this week. Doesn't matter which three — just spaced out, not back to back. Put them somewhere you'll see them. That's the entire task for Level 1: three sessions, done, in the diary before you think about a single exercise.

WHAT A SESSION ACTUALLY IS

For now, a session is 20 to 30 minutes of movement you don't hate. Walking fast, bodyweight squats and push-ups in your living room, a machine circuit at the gym, a class — it genuinely does not matter which. The only wrong answer is zero.

- Same three days each week if you can — routine beats motivation
- Put it in your calendar like an appointment, not a hope
- If you miss one, do it the next day. Don't wait for Monday

Nobody fails a fitness plan doing the wrong exercise. They fail it by not showing up. Fix that first and every other decision gets easier.

Before you move to Day 2, be honest with yourself: did you actually schedule three sessions this week, or just plan to? If you haven't opened your calendar yet, do it now — that's the whole test.

This is where most beginner programs skip straight to sets and reps. The full Lift It or Lose It guide builds Level 1 into an actual structured week — but the sequencing and progression logic only matters once the habit's locked in, which is what these nine days are for.

DAY 02 • NUTRITION LEVEL 01

EAT LIKE SOMEONE PAYING ATTENTION

Level 1 nutrition isn't a diet. It's noticing what you're already doing.

THE ONLY GOAL TODAY

For each meal today, ask one question before you eat: "where's the protein in this?" That's it. Not counting, not weighing — just noticing whether it's there or missing.

WHAT COUNTS AS PROTEIN-FORWARD

Eggs, chicken, beef, fish, Greek yoghurt, tofu, lentils, a protein shake if you're stuck. Aim for roughly a palm-sized serve at each meal — breakfast included, which is where almost everyone comes up short.

- If a meal has no obvious protein source, that's the gap to fix first
- Water before coffee, most mornings
- Don't change anything else yet — just notice

Most people aren't eating badly. They're eating randomly. Noticing is the first step out of random.

Before Day 3: did you actually check each meal today, or did you mean to and forget by lunch? If you forgot, that's fine — just start again tomorrow.

This is the noticing stage. The full Fuel It or Fail It guide takes this into an actual gram target based on your bodyweight and goal — that number matters, but it only means something once the noticing habit's already there.

DAY 03 • TRAINING LEVEL 02

PICK A SHAPE, NOT A WORKOUT

You've proven you'll show up. Now the three sessions get some structure.

THE FOUR MOVEMENT FAMILIES

Nearly everything useful in a gym falls into one of four buckets: squat (legs bend, knees lead), hinge (bend at the hips, back stays straight), push (moving weight away from you), pull (moving weight toward you). A session that touches most of these is doing its job, regardless of exact exercise.

BUILDING YOUR THREE SESSIONS

- Each session: one squat-pattern move, one hinge-pattern move, one push, one pull
- Bodyweight or machine versions are completely fine at this level
- Same rough shape each session — the exercises can vary, the pattern shouldn't

You don't need a program yet. You need a shape you repeat, so your body starts recognising what's coming.

Before Day 4: can you name which of the four patterns you hit in your last session? If you can't, that's the thing to fix this week — not the weight on the bar.

This is pattern-matching, not programming. The full Lift It or Lose It guide turns this into actual set and rep prescriptions — that's Level 3 and 4 territory, coming up.

DAY 04 • NUTRITION LEVEL 02

BUILD THE PLATE, DON'T COUNT IT

Now that you're noticing protein, it's time to build the rest of the plate around it.

THE ORDER THAT MATTERS

Protein first, onto the plate. Then vegetables. Then carbs. Then whatever fat's already come from the cooking. Most people build in the opposite order — carbs first, protein as an afterthought — and end up short on the one thing that matters most.

THE HAND METHOD

- Protein — a palm-sized serve
- Vegetables — a fist or more, go over on this one
- Carbs — a cupped handful
- Fat — a thumb's worth, if it's not already in the cooking

No app, no scale — just this order, most meals, most days.

Before Day 5: pick one meal today and build it in that order before you eat it. Did the plate look different than usual?

The hand method gets most people 80% of the way there. The other 20% — where exact numbers actually change the outcome — is what the full guide's calorie and macro chapters cover.

DAY 05 • TRAINING LEVEL 03

ADD SOME EFFORT

Three weeks of showing up and moving through patterns. Now we ask a bit more of each session.

INTRODUCING EFFORT

Every set you do sits somewhere on an effort scale — how many more reps you reckon you could've done before failing. At this level, aim to finish most working sets with 2 to 3 reps left in the tank. Not maxing out, not coasting either.

WHAT CHANGES THIS WEEK

- Same four patterns from Level 2, but pick a weight or resistance that challenges the last few reps
- 3 sets per exercise, most sessions
- If every set feels easy from rep one, the load's too light — nudge it up next session

This is where training stops being "moving around" and starts being training. The effort is the whole point now.

Before Day 6: on your hardest set this week, did the last 2 reps actually feel hard? If not, that's next session's fix.

This effort scale has a proper name — RPE, rate of perceived exertion — and it's how real programs are built session to session. The full guide uses it properly; here it's just the concept.

DAY 06 • NUTRITION LEVEL 03

THE NUMBER UNDERNEATH EVERYTHING

Time to introduce the one rule every approach to eating runs on, whether it says so or not.

ENERGY IN, ENERGY OUT

Eat more energy than you burn, you gain weight. Eat less, you lose it. Every diet that's ever worked, works through this — some just hide it better than others.

A GENERAL STARTING POINT

Most people looking to lose fat do well starting with a deficit of roughly 300–500 calories a day below what they currently maintain on. Small enough to hold onto muscle and stick with; small enough that one bad day doesn't undo the week.

- This is a general figure, not your figure — it depends on your size, activity, and goal
- Don't chase a bigger deficit hoping for faster results — it backfires
- Keep building the plate from Day 4 rather than switching to counting yet

Before Day 7: without changing anything, would you guess you're currently eating more, less, or about the same as you burn? You'll find out how right you were later.

Working out your actual number — not a general range — is exactly what the full Fuel It or Fail It guide walks through, chapter by chapter.

DAY 07 • TRAINING LEVEL 04

PROGRESS ON PURPOSE

Same sessions, same patterns — but now they need to change week to week, or they stop working.

PROGRESSIVE OVERLOAD

The name for "do slightly more over time than you did last time" — a bit more weight, a rep or two more, or the same weight with better form. Bodies only adapt to demands they haven't already met.

APPLYING IT THIS WEEK

- Write down what you did last session for each exercise — weight, sets, reps
- Next time, try to beat one of those numbers, even slightly
- If you can't beat any of them, that's your body asking for a rest day, not a heavier week
- Track it somewhere — notes app, whiteboard, doesn't matter
- Small, consistent increases beat big inconsistent jumps
- Tempo (how slowly you lower the weight) is another lever — worth knowing exists, not worth chasing yet

Before Day 8: did you beat last session's numbers on at least one exercise? If not, was it a bad day or has this week just been a lot?

This is the mechanism behind every real program. The full Lift It or Lose It guide builds a proper 8–12 week progression around it — this is the concept, that's the execution.

DAY 08 · NUTRITION LEVEL 04

MACROS, BRIEFLY

Last nutrition step before we wrap this up. This one's the deepest we'll go here.

THE THREE THAT MATTER

Protein, carbohydrate, and fat each supply energy, but they do different jobs. Protein repairs and keeps you full. Carbs fuel hard training. Fat runs your hormones and helps absorb certain vitamins. None of them are the enemy — they're just tools with different jobs.

THE ORDER TO SET THEM

- Total calories first (Day 6)
- Protein next — roughly 1.6–2g per kilogram of bodyweight is a common target
- Fat — don't take it below about 0.6g per kilogram, it costs you more than it saves
- Whatever's left over becomes carbs — this is the flexible one

Before Day 9: if you added up today's protein, do you reckon you hit anywhere near that range? Most people are surprised by how far short they are.

This is where "general" stops being enough — your actual numbers depend on your weight, activity, and goal, worked out properly in the full guide or in coaching.

DAY 09 • FINALLY

WHERE THIS ACTUALLY GOES

Nine days. Two tracks. Nothing here was complicated — the skill was doing it in order, without skipping ahead.

WHAT YOU'VE ACTUALLY BUILT

A habit of showing up. A shape for your sessions. A sense of what's on your plate. An idea of energy in versus energy out. That's the entire foundation everything else gets built on — and most people never get this far before jumping to something complicated.

WHERE THIS GUIDE STOPS ON PURPOSE

Levels 1 through 4 are the floor, not the ceiling. What comes after — actual programmed training weeks, your real calorie and macro numbers, adjustments as you progress — is deliberately left out of a free nine-day guide, because it needs to be built around you, not handed to everyone the same way.

One honest question before you go: of the nine days, which one did you actually skip or half-do? Start there again before you go looking for the next thing.

If you want this built around your body, your goals, and your actual week — that's what Hayden Cleary Fitness does.

— **Hayden**